

DANIEL SABEY

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EDUCATION

PhD Candidate of Economics Cornell University

August 2021 - Present

Chair: Mike Lovenheim

Committee Members: Sule Alan and Evan Riehl

MA Economics Cornell University

August 2023

BS Economics Brigham Young University (3.97 GPA)

April 2020

Minors in Math, Business, and Korean (4.0 GPA)

Brigham Young University Academic Full Tuition Scholarship for 4 Years

Magna Cum Laude

PUBLISHED PAPERS

“The Decline in Time to Bachelor’s Degree.” With Denning, J. T., Eide, E. R., & Mumford, K. J., (2022). *Economics of Education Review*, 90, 102287.

After increasing in the 1970s and 1980s, time to bachelor’s degree has declined since the 1990s. We document this fact using data from three nationally representative surveys. We show that this pattern is occurring across school types and for all student types. Using administrative student records from 10 large universities, we confirm the finding and show that it is robust to alternative sample definitions. We discuss what might explain the decline in time to bachelor’s degree by considering trends in student preparation, state funding, student enrollment, study time, and student employment during college.

WORKING PAPERS

“Association Between Recent Medicaid Expansions and Child Maltreatment Reporting and Outcomes” With Alex Hoagland.

Question. What was the association of recent Medicaid expansion in Maine on the volume and quality of child maltreatment reporting, and how did associations differ across children’s characteristics?

Findings. In this cohort study of 25,307,932 maltreatment reports across 38 states, Medicaid expansion in Maine led to increased overall reporting, particularly from medical professionals, resulting in increased separations at lower substantiation rates. Associations were stronger among Black and female children.

Meaning. Our results suggest recent Medicaid expansions are associated with increased maltreatment reporting and intervention at lower specificity, resulting in a greater rate of unsubstantiated separations of children from their caregivers.

“Locked Down and Lighting Up: Using COVID-19 Mobility Restrictions as an Instrument for Cigarette Stock and Smoking Intensity” With Don Kenkel and Alan Mathios.

This paper investigates the “temptation effect” – whether increased readily available cigarette stock causally increases smoking intensity. We leverage the unprecedented natural experiment of the COVID-19 pandemic using Nielsen household scanner data, Advan Patterns cell phone data, and USAfacts.org COVID-19 data. An Interrupted Time Series (ITS) model reveals COVID having a sharp and persistent increases in both cigarette stockpiles and smoking rates. Exploration of linked survey data highlights heterogeneous responses related to stress and household characteristics. To isolate the causal effect of stock, we use county-level changes in mobility as an instrumental variable (IV) for changes in cigarette stock. The IV estimates suggest that a one-pack increase in instrumented stock causally increases daily smoking by approximately one cigarette.

WORK IN PROGRESS

“Student Group Specific Teacher Learning” With Jason Cook.

This study investigates whether demographic-specific teaching skills are learnable by leveraging a natural experiment in the Columbus City Schools district. In 2003, the district shifted from race-specific to race-blind magnet school lotteries, causing significant changes to the racial composition of its schools. This paper examines how this policy change affected teacher effectiveness for different student populations and across various outcomes. Using a two-way fixed-effect model, the research analyzes how the lottery-induced changes in classroom demographics impacted teacher value-added, calculated separately before and after the policy change. By comparing these effects across different types of student outcomes (e.g., academic, behavioral), the study aims to reveal whether teachers can adapt to demographic shifts and which aspects of teaching effectiveness are most malleable mid-career.

“Improving Teacher Student Matching: Comparative Advantage or Machine Learning”

This paper explores methods to optimize teacher-student pairings by moving beyond single value-added metrics. It investigates which student characteristics (race, sex, prior performance, etc.) offer the greatest potential for gains when matching teachers based on their comparative advantages. The research introduces a novel method for classifying student “types” based on their past performance with different teachers and compares the effectiveness of traditional value-added models against higher-dimensional machine learning predictions for creating optimal classroom assignments. The paper also considers the welfare implications of reassigning students to teachers, rather than teachers to classes, and proposes an RCT to test these matching strategies in a real-world setting.

“Algorithmic Predictions of Student Outcomes” With Jake Meyer.

This project examines how predictive algorithms could be used to identify and help K-6 students who are at risk of academic setbacks. These setbacks include failing a class, scoring below proficiency on state exams, and failing to meet attendance requirements. This project will develop a machine learning (ML) tool to predict K-6 students’ risk of academic setbacks, and introduce the ML tool to six K-6 schools in a staggered-rollout RCT. We will use student data and teacher surveys to evaluate how the tool, and certain aspects of its implementation, affect student outcomes and teacher beliefs/effort, as well as to compare ML and teacher predictions. We hope to learn when a ML tool can add value in identifying at-risk students, and how the tool can be implemented to maximize improvement of student outcomes.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Cornell University

Graduate Research Assistant

Worked with four professors:

Mike Lovenheim

Donald Kenkel

Alan Mathios

Chen Qiu

August 2023-Present

Ithaca, New York

Brigham Young University

Pre-doctoral Research Assistant

Pre-doc with Joe Price

Collaborated closely on an RCT with Phil Oreopoulos

January 2020-July 2021

Provo, Utah

Brigham Young University

Research Assistant

Worked with three professors:

Jeff Denning

Eric Eide

Lars Lefgren

April 2019-May 2020

Provo, Utah

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Cornell Prison Education Program

Sole Instructor

Intro to Microeconomics

January 2026-Present

Ithaca, New York

Brigham Young University
Sole Instructor
Econ 110: Principles of Economics

Summer 2025
Provo, Utah

Cornell University
Graduate Teaching Assistant
Worked with two professors:
George Boyer: The History of Economic Thought and Institutions
Stephanie Thomas: Labor Economics

August 2022-May 2023
Ithaca, New York

Brigham Young University
Teaching Assistant
Worked with 6 professors:
Val Lambson: Game Theory and Economics
Joe Price: Principles of Economics
Arden Pope: Principles of Economics
Jim Kearn: Principles of Economics
Brennan Platt: Principles of Economics
Kristina Bishop: Principles of Economics

September 2017-September 2019
Provo, Utah

Brigham Young University
Student Consultant on Teaching
I worked with professors to improve teaching

September 2017-December 2019
Provo, Utah

SERVICE EXPERIENCE

Cornell University
Co-Chair: Cornell Heterodox Academy Campus Community

2024-Present
Ithaca, New York

SKILLS

Coding Expertise	STATA, Python, Latex
Coding Experience	SQL, MATLAB, R, Git, SLURM, Bash, SASS, Computer Vision
Languages	English (native), Korean (advanced)

ACHIEVEMENTS/AWARDS

Founder’s Dissertation Fellowship Award
Sage Fellowship
Deans List (x5)
National Merit Scholar
BYU Racquetball Team Member
Eagle Scout